The mountains to the southeast of Kābul, such as those of Khwāja Ismā‘īl, Dasht, Dūgī (Dūkī), and Afghānistān, were all much alike.

They were low, lacked vegetation, had limited water sources, and were devoid of trees. These regions were unattractive and unproductive. Their inhabitants reflected the nature of their surroundings, as the saying went, ‘As the place, so the people.’ It was quite possible that there were few mountains in the world as unproductive and repugnant as these.

j. Firewood of Kābul

With heavy snowfall in Kābul, it was fortunate that excellent firewood was readily available nearby. In just one day’s effort, one could obtain wood from the Khānjak (mastic), bīlūt (holm-oak), bādāmcha (small-almond), and qarqand trees. Among these, Khānjak wood had been the best choice. It burned with a bright flame, produced plenty of hot ashes, and had a pleasant aroma. It had also performed well even if it was somewhat sappy. Holm-oak had also been considered top-notch firewood, although it had a slightly lower flame than mastic. Similar to mastic, it had generated a fire with ample hot ashes and a pleasant scent. Holm-oak had the unique feature that when its leafy branches were ignited, they had crackled and blazed from the bottom to the top, providing an enjoyable experience during burning.

The wood from the small almond tree had been the most abundant and widely used, although it hadn’t sustained a fire for an extended period. Qarqand had been a low, thorny shrub suitable for burning whether it was sappy or dry, and it had been the preferred fuel for the people of Ghaznī.

k. Fauna of Kābul

The cultivated lands of Kābul were situated between mountains that served as natural barriers, resembling large dams, surrounding the flat valley-bottoms where most villages and settlements were located. On these mountains, kīyik and āhū were rarely found. Across these mountains, connecting their summer and winter habitats, the dun sheep, known as arqārghalcha, followed a regular migratory route. Brave hunters ventured out with dogs and birds to capture them. Towards Khūrd-kābul and the Sūrkh-rūd region, wild asses were present, but there were no white kīyik at all. Ghaznī, on the other hand, had both species, and few other places could boast of white kīyik found in such good condition.